

PLAYING UP

PLAYING UP IS NOT
A PUNISHMENT



WHEN YOUR COACH ENTERS THE TEAM IN AN OLDER DIVISION, THERE'S A REASON — AND IT'S ABOUT DEVELOPMENT, NOT RESULTS.



THE SERIES

FIVE LESSONS. ONE PLAYER.

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Playing Up Is Not a Punishment

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What Playing Up Actually Teach

Coming up.

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The Mental Side of Playing Up

Coming up.

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When Playing Up Is Used Strategically

Coming up.

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Preparing Your Athlete for Challenges Before They Arrive

Coming up.

HEAR THIS ONCE

PARENTS SEE AN OLDER DIVISION
ENTRY AND THINK THE COACH IS
SETTING THE TEAM UP TO FAIL.
COACHES SEE IT AS THE FASTEST
PATH TO GROWTH.

High-performance teams don't train to win early tournaments. They train to peak at the right time — qualifiers, championships, nationals. Playing up is preparation for that peak, not evidence of the coach's confusion.

— PLAY UP TO TRAIN FOR WHERE THE SEASON IS GOING · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE STRATEGIC FRAME

PLAYING UP ISN'T ABOUT THE
RESULT AT THE NEXT
TOURNAMENT. IT'S ABOUT WHO
THE TEAM BECOMES BY THE END
OF THE SEASON.

- High-performance teams peak at championships, not early tournaments
- Playing up accelerates the timeline, athletes face challenges that don't exist in their own division
- The discomfort is the point: growth lives in the gap between where you are and where the competition is

— TRAIN FOR WHERE THE SEASON ENDS. NOT WHERE IT STARTS.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

WHY COACHES PLAY UP

PLATEAU PREVENTION

Teams that always face familiar opponents stop being challenged, game slows down, decisions get easier.

COMPETITIVE EXPOSURE

Bigger, faster, stronger players force faster decisions and tighter execution, this is training.

PEAK TIMING

The goal is to be the best version of the team by nationals, not by October.



REFRAMING RESULTS

IN PRACTICE

After a loss in an older division: 'What did you learn about your game that you wouldn't have learned otherwise?'

WATCH FOR

Whether athletes interpret the loss as failure or as data, this is the entire mindset lesson.

THE SHIFT

From measuring the tournament by wins and losses to measuring it by growth indicators.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS · COME BACK TO IT

THE TEAM THAT TRAINS UP COMES
OUT DIFFERENT THAN THE TEAM THAT
ALWAYS TRAINS COMFORTABLE.
EMBRACE THE DIFFERENCE.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE GROWTH LAW

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, REFRAME ONE LOSS.

- ✓ After the next difficult match or tournament, ask: 'What did we learn that we couldn't have learned in our own division?'
- ✓ Name three specific growth observations, not excuses, observations
- ✓ Share the reframe with your athlete before the next tournament
- ✓ Notice: does her approach to difficult competition change when she understands the strategy?



PLAYING UP

WHAT PLAYING UP
ACTUALLY TEACHES

02

BIGGER BLOCKS, FASTER TEMPOS, LESS MARGIN FOR ERROR. THIS IS ELITE TRAINING IN DISGUISE.



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THE DISCOMFORT OF FACING OLDER,
STRONGER ATHLETES IS NOT A
PROBLEM TO BE MANAGED. IT IS THE
TRAINING STIMULUS YOUR ATHLETE
CANNOT GET ANY OTHER WAY.

You don't learn to beat a bigger block by avoiding it. You learn by seeing it, feeling it, adjusting to it, and failing against it until your technique forces the decision. That is what playing up delivers.

— DAPTATION ONLY HAPPENS UNDER PRESSURE · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE ADAPTATION MODEL

PLAYING UP CREATES CONDITIONS
WHERE ADAPTATION IS FORCED.
YOU CAN'T STAY THE SAME WHEN
THE COMPETITION IS AT A
DIFFERENT LEVEL.

- Faster tempo: decisions that used to have a quarter-second now have a tenth
- Bigger physical play: serving, blocking, and hitting are all more intense
- Tighter execution: the margin for error that exists in their division does not exist here

— YOU ADAPT TO THE LEVEL YOU TRAIN AT. PLAY UP TO RAISE THE FLOOR.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

THE SPECIFIC ADAPTATIONS

DECISION SPEED

Against older competition, read-and-react must happen faster, this training cannot be replicated in practice drills.



EXECUTION PRECISION

Sloppy technique that 'works' in their own division gets exposed against better competition.

MENTAL TOUGHNESS

Facing adversity: losing sets, being physically outmatched, builds the mental framework that competition requires.



HARVESTING THE ADAPTATIONS

IN PRACTICE

After playing up, ask: 'What was one thing you had to do differently than you normally do?'

WATCH FOR

Whether those adaptations show up in their regular division afterward, this is the payoff.

THE SHIFT

From 'we lost' to 'what specifically got better because of this challenge?'



SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

THE LOSS AGAINST THE OLDER TEAM
IS THE TRAINING. THE WIN AGAINST
THE SAME-AGE TEAM AFTERWARD IS
THE PROOF.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE ADAPTATION LAW

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, NAME ONE ADAPTATION FROM A HARD MATCH.

- ✓ After a challenging match: 'Name one thing you had to do differently than usual.'
- ✓ Help her see it as training, not failure: 'That challenge is why this game got harder for you, in a good way.'
- ✓ Watch for that adaptation showing up in the next same-division match
- ✓ Name it when you see it: 'That was the play up match paying off.'



PLAYING UP

THE MENTAL SIDE
OF PLAYING UP

03

PHYSICAL CHALLENGE IS EASY TO SEE. THE MENTAL CHALLENGE IS WHERE THE REAL WORK HAPPENS.



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ATHLETES WHO AREN'T PREPARED
MENTALLY FOR PLAYING UP
INTERPRET STRUGGLE AS FAILURE
— AND THAT INTERPRETATION
ERASES THE TRAINING BENEFIT.

Good coaches are intentional about how and when they introduce playing up. They prepare athletes mentally before the physical challenge arrives — so that difficulty is interpreted as training, not as evidence of inadequacy.

— PREPARE THE MIND BEFORE THE BODY ARRIVES · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE MENTAL PREPARATION

BEFORE THE TEAM PLAYS UP, THE MENTAL FRAME HAS TO BE SET — OR THE PHYSICAL CHALLENGE BECOMES A CONFIDENCE PROBLEM.

- Brief the team: 'This is training. We are here to be challenged, not to be perfect.'
- Define success differently: 'Today, success is executing under pressure, not the score.'
- Debrief with intention: after the match, name what the team did well under pressure

— MENTAL PREPARATION IS NOT OPTIONAL WHEN THE PHYSICAL CHALLENGE IS THIS HIGH.

THE MENTAL RISKS

CONFIDENCE COLLAPSE

An athlete who interprets losing to an older team as evidence of her own inadequacy is not being trained, she is being damaged.



EFFORT TIGHTENING

Under extreme pressure without mental preparation, athletes tighten and stop playing free.

COACH-ATHLETE TRUST

If the athlete doesn't understand why she's being put in this position, she may lose trust in the coach's judgment.

THE PRE-MATCH FRAME

IN PRACTICE

Before the match: 'We are here to train. The challenge IS the point. This is going to be hard and that is the goal.'

WATCH FOR

Whether athletes shrink or expand under the pressure of the harder competition.

THE SHIFT

From hoping athletes will cope to deliberately preparing them to thrive in challenge.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

A TEAM THAT KNOWS WHY THEY'RE
PLAYING UP PLAYS DIFFERENTLY THAN
ONE THAT DOESN'T. FRAME IT
BEFORE THEY COMPETE.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, HAVE THE PRE-CHALLENGE CONVERSATION.

- ✓ Before the next challenging match, take two minutes to frame the purpose
- ✓ 'This will be hard. Hard is the point. Tell me after: what did you learn?'
- ✓ After: debrief on growth observations, not on the score
- ✓ Notice whether the framing changes how athletes talk about the match in the car ride home



PLAYING UP

WHEN PLAYING UP
IS USED STRATEGICALLY



GOOD COACHES DON'T THROW TEAMS IN BLINDLY. THERE'S A METHOD — AND KNOWING IT HELPS PARENTS TRUST IT.



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EFFECTIVE COACHES DON'T USE PLAYING UP RANDOMLY. THEY USE IT STRATEGICALLY, AND THE PATTERN REVEALS THEIR THINKING ABOUT WHERE THE TEAM IS IN ITS DEVELOPMENT ARC.

Understanding the strategic logic behind playing up transforms the parent's role from anxious spectator to informed partner. When you know why the challenge is happening and what it's building toward, you can support your athlete through it rather than inadvertently undermining it.

— UNDERSTAND THE STRATEGY BEFORE YOU REACT TO THE RESULT · MAZEPERFORMANCE

THE STRATEGIC LOGIC

EFFECTIVE COACHES SEQUENCE
CHALLENGE DELIBERATELY.
UNDERSTANDING THE SEQUENCE
IS THE KEY TO SUPPORTING IT.

- Build confidence first: early season matches where the team can succeed and find rhythm
- Introduce challenge: as the season progresses, gradually introduce higher competition
- Peak preparation: by championship season, the team has faced, and been built by, the hardest competition available

— STRATEGIC CHALLENGE IS SEQUENCED. UNDERSTAND THE SEQUENCE.

05 · THE BREAKDOWN

READING THE STRATEGY

CONFIDENCE BUILDING PHASE

Early season: matches the team can win. Foundation of confidence and team cohesion.

CHALLENGE INTRODUCTION

Mid-season: playing up begins. Growth stimulus is intentional and purposeful.

CHAMPIONSHIP PREPARATION

Late season: competition level is as high as the team will face at its peak event.



B E C O M I N G A N I N F O R M E D P A R T N E R

IN PRACTICE

Ask the coach (in the right moment): 'Can you help me understand the competition strategy this season?'

WATCH FOR

The pattern across tournaments, is the challenge level increasing as the season progresses?

THE SHIFT

From reacting to individual tournament results to reading the arc of the full season.



07 · REMEMBER THIS

SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

TRUST THE SEQUENCE. THE LOSS IN
OCTOBER IS OFTEN THE INVESTMENT
THAT PAYS OUT IN MARCH.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, READ THE SEASON ARC.

✓ Map the tournament schedule: what is the competition level at each point in the season?

✓ Notice: is it escalating intentionally as the season progresses?

✓ If unclear, ask the coach: 'What's the thinking behind the tournament schedule this season?'

✓ Share the understanding with your athlete: 'Here's why this challenge is happening now.'



PREPARING YOUR ATHLETE FOR CHALLENGE BEFORE IT ARRIVES

05

THE ATHLETE WHO KNOWS WHY THE CHALLENGE EXISTS SHOWS UP DIFFERENTLY THAN THE ONE WHO DOESN'T.

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HEAR THIS ONCE

MOST ATHLETES EXPERIENCE
PLAYING UP WITHOUT ANY
EXPLANATION, AND INTERPRET THE
DIFFICULTY THROUGH WHATEVER
FRAME THEY BRING.

The athlete who knows: 'We are here to be challenged, not to be perfect. The discomfort IS the training' will perform differently in those matches than the one who thinks: 'We're losing because we're not good enough.' Frame it before it happens.

THE PRE-CHALLENGE BRIEF

CONTEXT CHANGES EXPERIENCE.
GIVE YOUR ATHLETE THE
CONTEXT BEFORE THE CHALLENGE
ARRIVES.

- Brief her: 'This match is training. We are here to be stretched, not to be perfect.'
- Name the specific challenge: 'Their blockers are bigger. Their tempo is faster. That's the point.'
- Define success: 'Success today is: one good decision under pressure. Not the score.'

— THE ATHLETE WHO KNOWS WHY SHE IS FACING THIS CHALLENGE MEETS IT DIFFERENTLY.

THE CONTEXT SHIFT

WITHOUT CONTEXT

'We lost. The other team was so much better. We couldn't do anything.'

WITH CONTEXT

'That was hard, exactly like we knew it would be. What one thing got better because of it?'

THE DIFFERENCE

Context transforms a discouraging result into a meaningful development experience.



THE PRE-CHALLENGE CONVERSATION

IN PRACTICE

Before the next challenging match, take three minutes to brief her on the purpose.

WATCH FOR

Whether her body language going into the match reflects purpose or anxiety.

THE SHIFT

From walking into challenge cold to walking in with a frame that makes it manageable.



SAVE THIS COME BACK TO IT

CONTEXT IS THE DIFFERENCE
BETWEEN A DISCOURAGING LOSS AND
A MEANINGFUL TRAINING
EXPERIENCE. GIVE HER THE CONTEXT.

SAVE THIS. COME BACK TO IT.

— THE CONTEXT LAW

THIS WEEK

THIS WEEK, BRIEF YOUR ATHLETE BEFORE THE HARD MATCH.

- ✓ Before the next challenging match, deliver the pre-challenge brief
- ✓ 'This will be hard. Hard is the point. Success today is: one thing you do better under pressure.'
- ✓ After the match, ask: 'What was the one thing?', and celebrate it specifically
- ✓ Build this into your pre-match ritual for every challenging competition

